

Emergency Medicine Terminology Glossary

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Purpose

A reference glossary of common terms used across emergency screens, workflows, and documentation.

Terms

Term	Definition
Triage	The process of sorting patients by the urgency of their condition.
Acuity	A measure of how urgently a patient requires care.
Chief Complaint	The primary reason a patient is seeking care, in their own words.
Disposition	The next step in a patient's care, such as admission, discharge, or transfer.
Vital Signs	Core physiological measurements including blood pressure, heart rate, respiratory rate, and temperature.
Glasgow Coma Scale	A scoring system used to assess a patient's level of consciousness.
Code Team	A designated team that responds to life-threatening emergencies within a facility.
Boarding	A situation where an admitted patient remains in the emergency department awaiting an inpatient bed.
Rapid Response	An escalation process for a patient showing signs of clinical deterioration.
Observation Status	A category of care for patients who need monitoring but not full inpatient admission.
Mechanism of Injury	The way in which a traumatic injury occurred, used to guide assessment.
Sepsis	A life-threatening response to infection affecting multiple organ systems.
Crash Cart	A mobile cart stocked with emergency equipment and medications.
Handoff	The transfer of patient care responsibility and information between providers.
ESI	Emergency Severity Index, a common five-level triage acuity scale.

Reference Visual (Synthetic)

